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Seoul Travel Guide 2026 — Everything You Need to Know

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Seoul is one of Asia's most exciting cities — ancient palaces stand next to neon-lit streets, world-class food is everywhere, and the subway will take you almost anywhere. Here's everything you need to plan a great trip.

Getting to Seoul

Most international flights arrive at **Incheon International Airport (ICN)**, about 50 km west of central Seoul. Getting into the city is easy and affordable.

Option	Cost	Time	Best for
AREX Express Train	~₩9,500	43 min	Most travelers
AREX All-Stop Train	~₩4,850	66 min	Budget travelers
Airport Bus (limousine)	₩10,000–17,000	60–90 min	Heavy luggage, specific areas
Taxi / Kakao T	₩60,000–90,000	50–80 min	Groups, late night

Tip: Buy a **T-money card** at the airport convenience store (GS25, CU). It works on the subway, buses, and even some taxis across all of Korea.

Best Neighborhoods to Explore

Gyeongbokgung / Bukchon (Historic Seoul)

The heart of Joseon Dynasty history. Visit **Gyeongbokgung Palace** in the morning before the crowds, then walk through **Bukchon Hanok Village** — a neighborhood of preserved traditional Korean houses (hanok). The nearby **Insadong** area has great craft shops, galleries, and tea houses.

Hongdae (Youth & Nightlife)

The area around Hongik University is packed with indie music venues, street performers, affordable restaurants, and cafés. It's one of the best places for nightlife without spending a fortune. Great for people in their 20s and 30s.

Myeongdong (Shopping & Street Food)

Seoul's most famous shopping district. Packed with K-beauty stores, international brands, and incredible street food stalls. Try **tteokbokki** (spicy rice cakes), **hotteok** (sweet pancakes), and **egg bread** here.

Gangnam (Modern Seoul)

South of the Han River, Gangnam is sleek and upscale. Visit **COEX Mall** (huge underground mall with a stunning library), the **Bongeunsa Temple** for contrast, and the cafés and restaurants of **Garosu-gil**.

Itaewon (International Vibes)

Seoul's most international neighborhood. Restaurants serving food from every country, English-friendly bars, and a welcoming atmosphere for foreign visitors. The nearby **Leeum Museum of Art** is world-class.

Must-See Attractions

- **Gyeongbokgung Palace** — Free on the last Wednesday of each month; the changing of the guard ceremony is unmissable
- **N Seoul Tower (Namsan Tower)** — Great city views, especially at night
- **Bukchon Hanok Village** — Best visited on weekday mornings to avoid crowds
- **Lotte World Tower Observatory** — The highest observation deck in Korea

- **DMZ Tour** — A sobering and fascinating day trip to the Demilitarized Zone
- **Han River Parks** — Rent a bike, have a picnic, watch the sunset

Getting Around Seoul

Seoul's **subway system** is one of the best in the world — clean, punctual, and has English signage on every line. It connects virtually every major neighborhood and tourist site.

Seoul Subway Tips

Use the

Kakao Metro

or

Naver Map

app for real-time directions. Both have English modes. Always tap your T-money card when entering AND exiting — fares are calculated by distance.

For buses, the route system can be confusing at first. Stick to the subway if you're new. Taxis are plentiful and affordable — use **Kakao T** app to hail one (no language barrier needed).

Food You Must Try

- **Bibimbap** — Colorful rice bowl with vegetables, egg, and gochujang sauce
- **Korean BBQ (Samgyeopsal)** — Grilled pork belly, cook it at the table yourself
- **Kimchi jjigae** — Spicy kimchi stew, a Korean comfort food classic
- **Tteokbokki** — Chewy rice cakes in a spicy, slightly sweet sauce
- **Japchae** — Glass noodles stir-fried with vegetables and beef
- **Chimaek** — Korean fried chicken + beer, a perfect evening combo

Practical Tips

- **Money:** Korea is largely a card-friendly society, but carry some cash (KRW) for small street food stalls and traditional markets

- **Pocket WiFi / SIM:** Rent a pocket WiFi at the airport or buy a prepaid SIM (KT, SKT, U+). Data speeds are excellent everywhere
- **Safety:** Seoul is extremely safe. Violent crime is very rare. You can walk around late at night without worry
- **Best time to visit:** Spring (March–May) for cherry blossoms, Autumn (September–November) for foliage and clear skies
- **Tipping:** Not expected or common in Korea. Do not tip at restaurants

Download before you go: Naver Map (better than Google Maps in Korea), Kakao T (taxi), Papago (translation), and your bank's international app.

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